ROUTLEDGE DIRECT | CUSTOMER LIFECYCLE | OCTOBER 2025

CRM lifecycle plan

Who CRM writes to in FY2026, what each group gets, when, and how we will know it worked

For the CRM and email team. Built from the customer value analysis on customers up to 30 September 2025. Every audience in this plan is a filter on ecomrl.clean.customer_value, one row per customer. Gross profit is after discounts, refunds, product, delivery, payment fees and affiliate commission. Simulated data, not Taylor & Francis performance.

The plan in short

The plan runs four lifecycle programmes, one for each stage a customer can be in, timed to the academic calendar rather than to the days since someone last bought. It rests on four things the data shows clearly.

1. **The job is the second order.** 77.6 percent of the 58,101 customers have bought once, and only 969 have bought four times or more. There is no large loyal base to protect; there is a large one order base to convert. Mature customers who ordered again within a year added $122.65 of gross profit each from their later orders in that year.
2. **People come back for a later term, not the next month.** In the month after a first order 0.63 percent of customers buy again. The share climbs to 2.35 percent in month 8 and is still 2.14 percent in month 12. Over three years, January, August and September held 33.0 percent of all orders and June and July 13.8 percent; September alone held 12.9 percent. A "we miss you" email at day 30 lands in the quietest month of the customer's year.
3. **A sale code costs margin; any loyalty cost is too small to tell from noise.** Customers whose first order used a sale code are worth $92.54 of gross profit over twelve months against $126.01 for customers who first bought on an ordinary day. Most of that gap is the first order, which carries $32.12 of discount and earns $71.06 of gross profit against $102.47; within the same acquisition channel the repeat gap is too small to tell from noise. People who bought on a sale day without the code are the most valuable of the three first order groups: $138.97 and a 24.9 percent repeat rate.
4. **Reach is the same everywhere.** 64.0 percent of customers have opted in to email, and the share runs only from 62.7 to 65.9 percent across the RFM groups. That is **37,183 people** CRM can write to.

Every programme keeps a random holdout from the first send, so the business learns what CRM adds rather than what it is credited with: the 90 day measures for Cooling and Lapsed read within months, and the New programme's twelve month result once a full year's intake has had its twelve months.

Five rules every send follows

1. **Time sends to the term, not to the last order.** The big pushes go in the two to three weeks before the January and August term starts. Nothing chases a customer in the month after their first order except the order follow up and the welcome email, and sale emails skip anyone in that month.
2. **Codes only where they pay, and only while a sale runs.** The proposed rule is that codes go only to people whose first order used one, and everyone else hears about new titles at full price. Sale emails sit outside the four programmes and go to everyone outside the holdouts, whatever their stage; who gets a code in them follows the offer tests in the first sales of FY2026, before anything becomes permanent.
3. **Content follows the last purchase.** Titles are chosen from what the customer bought last, in the same format. Nothing about who gets which programme depends on subject.
4. **Frequency is capped.** One programme email a month at most, and two in January, August and September. The order follow up, the welcome and sale emails sit outside the cap.
5. **Every programme keeps a 20 percent holdout.** Without it, CRM will be credited with orders that might have happened anyway, the same question the business cannot yet answer for brand search and coupon partners.

Who we are writing to

Four lifecycle stages

Recency (days since the last order, to 30 September 2025) and frequency give ten RFM groups, which roll up into four stages. The stage decides **when** someone hears from us.

Stage	RFM groups in it	Who they are	People	Emailable	Lifetime gross profit each	Share of all gross profit
New	New customers, Promising	One order, placed in the last 284 days	15,851	10,162	$94.29	20.1%
Active repeat	Champions, Loyal, Potential loyalists	Two to seven orders, the last within 469 days	8,025	5,120	$273.51	29.6%
Cooling	Needs attention, About to sleep	One or two orders, the last 285 to 469 days ago	10,991	7,000	$109.89	16.3%
Lapsed	At risk, Hibernating, Lost	Last order 470 days ago or more, one to six orders	23,234	14,901	$108.63	34.0%
All			**58,101**	**37,183**	**$127.73**	**100%**

The stages line up with the calendar. Returns peak eight months after a first order, so New customers are heading into the months when returns are highest, and Cooling customers, 285 to 469 days out, are past the peak month.

The first order sale group

How the first order was priced decides **whether an email carries a code**.

First order	Mature customers	12 month gross profit	12 month repeat	First order discount
Sale, used the code	9,447	$92.54	18.0%	$32.12
Sale period, full price	4,126	$138.97	24.9%	$0
Outside any sale	22,996	$126.01	19.3%	$0

Mature customers only. The code group's 1.4 point repeat gap falls to 0.64 within the same acquisition channel, which is too small to tell from noise. Black Friday code customers took the deepest discount, $49.00, and are worth the least, $76.61.

The four programmes

The audiences

Stage	Sale, used the code	Sale period, full price	Outside any sale	All emailable
New	3,043 ($73.06)	1,329 ($108.94)	5,790 ($102.48)	10,162
Active repeat	1,143 ($235.52)	672 ($292.89)	3,305 ($287.73)	5,120
Cooling	2,218 ($79.39)	955 ($126.76)	3,827 ($124.16)	7,000
Lapsed	3,267 ($81.83)	1,381 ($125.17)	10,253 ($114.41)	14,901
All stages	**9,671**	**4,337**	**23,175**	**37,183**

Each cell is one filter on `customer_value`: people who have opted in, with lifetime gross profit per person so far in brackets. In every stage the same order holds: the code group is worth the least so far, full price sale day buyers the most, and ordinary day buyers sit between.

New: earn the second order

Audience: 10,162 emailable today, and about 13,700 more a year (21,532 customers placed their first order between October 2024 and September 2025, and 63.8 percent of them opted in).

When	Email	Content	Offer
Within 2 days of the order	Order follow up	How to access or track the book, author and companion resources	None
1 to 2 weeks after the order	Welcome	Two or three titles chosen from the first order, same format	None
3 weeks before the next term start	Second order prompt	Reading for the coming term, in the format they bought	Code group only: the sale code, if a sale is running
2 weeks after term start	Reminder to non openers	The same selection, shorter	As above

Between the welcome and the second order prompt, no programme emails. The next term start is whichever of January or August comes first after the first order; anyone whose first order falls less than a month before the prompt waits for the following term's.

Measure: twelve month repeat rate and gross profit per customer, programme against holdout.

Active repeat: keep them, and do not pay them to stay

Audience: 5,120 emailable. Champions average $490.96 of lifetime gross profit and Loyal customers $338.23.

What to send: new editions of titles they own, new books from authors they have bought, and term start reading lists. One email a month at most, two in January, August and September. No codes, except to the code group during a sale: these people already come back, and a discount to someone who would have paid full price is margin given away.

Measure: orders and gross profit per customer against holdout. If the programme does not beat its holdout, it is cut back to the term start sends only.

Cooling: one well timed attempt per term

Audience: 7,000 emailable, just past the usual return peak.

What to send: one email in the three weeks before each term start, built around the coming term, plus one follow up to non openers. No programme emails outside the term start windows.

Offer: the sale code to the code group if a sale is running, and no discount for anyone else.

Measure: share placing an order within 90 days of the send, and gross profit per recipient, against holdout.

Lapsed: low cost, and stop when it stops working

Audience: 14,901 emailable, the largest stage. Most are one order customers whose last order was more than fifteen months ago, and between them they still hold 34.0 percent of all lifetime gross profit, simply because there are so many of them.

What to send: the August and January term start emails only, two programme emails a year, alongside the sale emails everyone receives. Anyone who has received four term start emails without opening one is suppressed, to protect sender reputation.

Measure: share placing an order within 90 days against holdout, with unsubscribe and spam complaint rates as guardrails.

Offers, calendar, measurement and limits

The two offer tests

The one real change in offer policy is who gets a code. It is tested in the first sale of FY2026, Black Friday (20 November to 2 December 2025), on the people outside the programme holdouts and outside their first month, and the same split is kept for the New Year sale. The result covers both sales and is read in mid April, 90 days after the New Year sale ends, in time for the mid year sale.

Test	Audience	Split	Judged on
Do code customers need the code?	Up to about 7,700 of the 9,671 emailable customers whose first order used a code	Half get the sale email with the code, half a full price email	Gross profit per customer from Black Friday to 90 days after the New Year sale
Do sale emails earn their discount?	Up to about 22,000 of the other 27,512 emailable customers	Half get the sale email with the code, half a full price email	Gross profit per customer over the same period, with orders per customer as a guardrail

If the full price half keeps the gross profit and saves the discount, codes stop for that audience. If it loses gross profit, the sale email stays and the rule is rewritten.

The FY2026 calendar

Month	Main send	Who gets it
October	Reading for the rest of the autumn term	Active repeat
November	Black Friday sale, 20 November to 2 December, with the two offer tests	Everyone outside the holdouts and their first month, split as in the tests
December	Term start reading, and the second order prompt for New, three weeks before the January term	New, Active repeat, Cooling
January	Term start send; reminders to non openers. New Year sale, 3 to 18 January, on the same split	Lapsed, Active repeat; New and Cooling reminders
February to April	New editions and launches, one a month	Active repeat
May and June	Mid year sale, 20 May to 10 June	Sale email to everyone outside the holdouts, codes as the tests settled
July	Term start reading, and the second order prompt for New, three weeks before the August term	New, Active repeat, Cooling
August	Term start send; reminders to non openers. Back to college sale, 8 August to 24 September, sale email to everyone outside the holdouts, codes as the tests settled	Lapsed, Active repeat; New and Cooling reminders
September	Second term month email	Active repeat

Order follow up and welcome emails go out all year, as people buy.

The holdout

20 percent of each programme's audience is held out at random when the person enters the stage, stays out for twelve months and receives no programme emails and no sale emails, so the holdout result measures the two together. Order confirmations and other service emails still go. Holdout membership is stored, so a customer cannot drift between the two groups.

> **HOW BIG A LIFT THE NEW PROGRAMME CAN DETECT**
>
> About 13,700 new customers a year opt in. A 20 percent holdout is about 2,750 people, against about 10,990 who get the programme.
>
> The base twelve month repeat rate is 19.6 percent, on all mature customers; it is assumed to hold for those who opted in, since opt in barely differs between groups. With groups this size the smallest lift a two proportion test would reliably pick up (5 percent significance, two sided, 80 percent power) is about 2.4 points. A 10 percent holdout would only detect about 3.2 points, and 30 percent gets down to about 2.1. Twenty percent is the balance between learning something and holding customers back.
>
> Each extra point of repeat rate on the 10,990 who get the programme is about 110 more repeat customers, worth roughly 110 x $122.65 = about $13,500 of gross profit in their first year.

Every measure is in gross profit or in customers who bought, never in email platform revenue. Email platforms credit an order to any email opened within their attribution window before it, which counts orders that would have happened anyway.

Pulling an audience

Every audience comes from `ecomrl.clean.customer_value`. This query pulls the New customers who first bought at full price on a sale day and can be emailed, the New customers worth most so far.

```
select
  person_id,
  lifecycle_stage,
  first_order_price_group,
  recency_days,
  orders,
  round(gross_profit_usd, 2) as gross_profit_usd
from `ecomrl.clean.customer_value`
where marketing_opt_in
  and lifecycle_stage = 'New'
  and first_order_price_group = 'sale period, full price'
order by recency_days;

-- Result: 1,329 rows.
```

Stages, RFM groups, opt in and the audience table come from `05_customer_value.sql` and Section 6 of `01_customer_value.ipynb`; retention from its Section 2; repeat rate, twelve month value and the sale groups from its Sections 3 and 5. The other sizes in the plan come from three more queries on the same tables.

```
-- Orders by month of the year, all three years
select extract(month from order_date) as month_num, count(*) as orders
from `ecomrl.clean.orders`
group by extract(month from order_date)
order by month_num;
-- Result: January 7,053, August 8,197 and September 9,793 of 75,918 orders (33.0
-- percent together); June 5,340 and July 5,101 (13.8 percent).

-- First time customers in FY2025, and how many opted in
select count(*) as people, countif(marketing_opt_in) as opted_in
from `ecomrl.clean.customer_value`
where first_order_date between date '2024-10-01' and date '2025-09-30';
-- Result: 21,532 people, 13,736 opted in (63.8 percent).

-- What a repeat customer adds, mature customers only
select
  repeated_within_12m,
  count(*) as people,
  round(avg(gross_profit_12m_usd), 2) as gp_12m_per_person,
  round(avg(gross_profit_12m_usd - first_order_gross_profit_usd), 2) as later_gp_per_person
from `ecomrl.clean.customer_value`
where has_full_12m
group by repeated_within_12m;
-- Result: 7,175 repeat customers at $228.84 each, $122.65 of it from orders after the
-- first; 29,394 who did not order again within twelve months, at $91.97.
```

Any cell of the audience table is the same query with a different stage and price group. The table is rebuilt by `05_customer_value.sql` and should be refreshed monthly, with the date recency is counted to (30 September 2025 here) moved to the refresh date, so people move between stages as they buy or go quiet. Every column is described in the data dictionary.

Limits of this plan

- **Email cost is not in the data.** Gross profit per recipient can be measured, but the cost of sending cannot be netted off, so CRM's return on cost is unknown.
- **There is no person level email data.** No sends, opens or clicks by customer, so the plan is built on buying behaviour only, and the holdout results will be the first person level measure CRM has.
- **Most customers are known from one order.** For 77.6 percent of them the stage and the sale group rest on a single purchase, which is another reason to refresh monthly.
- **The full price sale day effect is unexplained.** These customers are worth more and come back more often, and the data does not say why. The plan protects them without claiming to know the reason.